

People tend to believe that they are less vulnerable to negative outcomes or events than others. This is known as the self-positivity bias, a specific type of attributional bias in social psychology. Health psychologists suggest that the self-positivity bias may prevent people from being persuaded to take precautionary measures against certain health risks because behavior change is predicated on the perceived risk of contracting the disease in question. If a persuasive message cannot overcome the self-positivity bias, then behavior change is unlikely.

In Study 1, researchers hypothesized that when told that an infectious disease can be contracted by engaging in likely or common behavior, people will experience less self-positivity bias than when told the disease can be contracted through unlikely or uncommon behavior. Ninety participants were randomly assigned to a likely/common group, an unlikely/uncommon group, and a control group. All participants read the same paragraph about the health consequences of viral meningitis and how it is contracted. For the likely/common group, the paragraph included, "Viral meningitis is caused by enteroviruses (common virus causing 'stomach flulike' symptoms) and can be contracted through close contact (touching, kissing) with an infected person." For the unlikely/uncommon group, the paragraph included, "Viral meningitis is caused by lymphocytic choriomeningitis virus and can be contracted through coming into contact with the blood, feces, urine, or saliva of an infected mouse." All participants were asked to estimate the likelihood of contracting the disease themselves and the likelihood for the average person (Table 1).

Table 1 Mean Estimated Probability of Contracting Viral Meningitis, by Group

	Likely/common group	Unlikely/uncommon group	Control
Self	35	20	22
Average person	47	41	42

In Study 2, 120 participants read a newspaper article about hepatitis C and were then randomly assigned to one of four experimental conditions, each receiving additional information about either two or eight relatively uncommon behaviors (eg, getting a tattoo, sharing a needle) or relatively common behaviors (eg, sharing a toothbrush, not bandaging a cut) that could spread the disease. Participants rated their concern for contracting hepatitis C on a scale of 1 (not at all concerned) to 7 (most concerned) (Table 2).

Table 2 Mean Concern of Contracting Hepatitis C Score, by Group and Condition

Number of behaviors	Common behaviors	Uncommon behaviors
Two	4.34	2.22
Eight	5.16	3.00

The foot-in-the-door phenomenon predicts that:

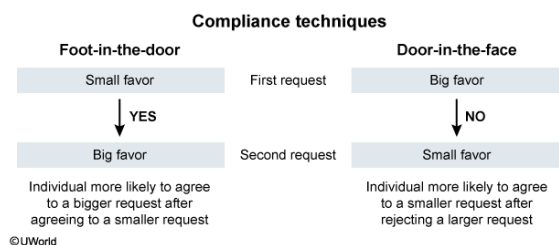
- ☐ A. individuals who have just taken a hepatitis C blood test would be the most likely to agree to participate in Study 2. [8%]

- ☐ B. if the Study 2 researchers first ask individuals to take a hepatitis C blood test, those who decline will be more likely to participate in the research study. [3%]
- ☐ C. more participants in Study 2 would be willing to take a hepatitis C blood test than participants in Study 1. [4%]
- ✓ ☒ D. after agreeing to participate in Study 2, individuals would be more likely to agree to a request to take a hepatitis C blood test. [84%]

Correct

84% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **foot-in-the-door strategy** is a compliance technique (meant to persuade someone to act) that involves **first** asking a **small favor** of someone, something that is easy to do and requires little effort or expense (eg, participation in a research study). Once the small favor is granted, a much larger favor (eg, taking a hepatitis C blood test) is requested.

The foot-in-the-door phenomenon can be explained by the fact that **behavior influences attitude**: granting a small favor causes the individual to have a more positive attitude toward the person just helped, increasing the likelihood that the individual will agree to the larger favor.

(Choice A) Agreeing to a big favor first and then a smaller favor is the opposite of the foot-in-the-door phenomenon.

(Choice B) The door-in-the-face phenomenon predicts that an individual declining a big request (taking a hepatitis C blood test) will be more likely to comply with a subsequent request that is much smaller (participating in the research study).

(Choice C) There is nothing about the foot-in-the-door phenomenon to suggest that the participants in Study 2 would be more agreeable to taking a hepatitis C test than those in Study 1 as the relative difficulties of the tasks in both studies were approximately the same.

Educational objective:

The foot-in-the-door phenomenon predicts that people are more likely to comply with a big request after they have already complied with a small request. This can be explained by a change in attitude: people tend to have more favorable attitudes toward those they have just helped, increasing the likelihood they will agree to the larger request.

Time spent: 0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID: 400501

System:

Identity and Social Interaction

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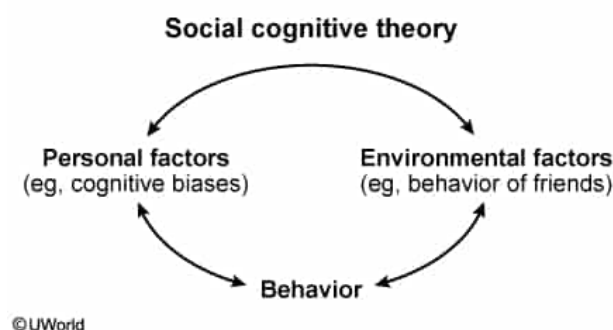
A proponent of social cognitive theory would suggest that the self-positivity bias is unlikely to influence an individual:

- ☐ A. with hepatitis A. [13%]
- ☐ B. studying hepatitis C in a liver cell line. [6%]
- ✓ ☒ C. with several friends who have hepatitis C. [52%]
- ☐ D. who has never heard of hepatitis C. [27%]

Correct

53% answered correctly

Explanation:



Social cognitive theory suggests that people **learn through observing others**. Watching a model (someone else, often a friend or family member) engaging in a behavior and the consequences associated with that behavior is a powerful method of learning called **vicarious learning**. Depending on the outcome for the model, the observer may replicate or avoid that behavior.

According to social cognitive theory, people would be least susceptible to the self-positivity bias (the belief that they are immune to negative outcomes such as contracting hepatitis C) if they had friends with the disease. People tend to share similar characteristics with and behave in ways similar to those of their friends. Therefore, individuals who have friends with hepatitis C would have already observed the behaviors associated with contracting it and so would be less inclined to assume they are immune to the disease.

(Choices A, B, and D) Social cognitive theory is most concerned with how individuals learn through observing the behaviors of others. Therefore, a proponent of this theory would be concerned with how an individual's behavior and attitudes are shaped by interacting with others, rather than through personal

experience with a similar disease, professional experience with the disease, or lack of knowledge about the disease.

Educational objective:

Social cognitive theory posits that people learn by observing others. Vicarious learning takes place through watching other people behave in a certain way and then get rewarded or punished for it. Depending on the outcome, the observer

may or may not choose to behave in the same way as the model.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400502

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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Table 2 Mean Concern of Contracting Hepatitis C Score, by Group and Condition

Number of behaviors	Common behaviors	Uncommon behaviors
Two	4.34	2.22
Eight	5.16	3.00

According to the elaboration likelihood model, which of the following should generate the most concern about the risks of contracting hepatitis C in the two-uncommon-behaviors group from Study 2? A television commercial showing:

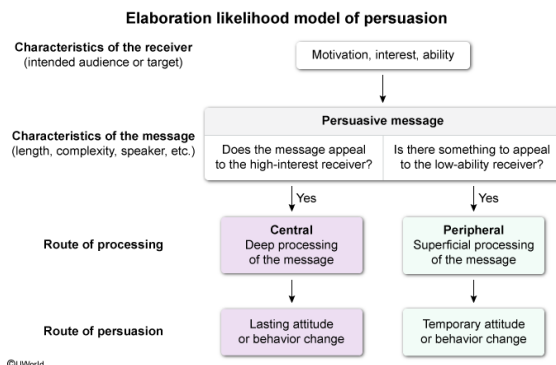
- ☐ A. text detailing the scientific facts about contracting hepatitis C. [5%]

- ☐ B. actual drug addicts sharing needles. [17%]
- ✓ ☒ C. an attractive celebrity using a catchy phrase to summarize the main hepatitis C risk factors. [42%]
- ☐ D. a medical expert from a prestigious university summarizing the main hepatitis C risk factors. [35%]

Correct

41% answered correctly

Explanation:



The **elaboration likelihood model of persuasion** describes **two routes** by which a message can cause attitude change in the receiver (the person for whom the message was intended). Either route can result in persuasion, but the **central route** is **more effective** when people are **willing** and **able** to **pay attention** to the facts, whereas the **peripheral route** is **more effective** when people are **not paying close attention** to the content of the message.

The **central route** of processing occurs when the message characteristics engage the receiver in a **deep, meaningful** way, often through the use of a well-reasoned argument emphasizing the logical content of the message. The **peripheral route** of processing occurs when the message characteristics engage the receiver in a more **superficial** way, often through methods that do not require a great deal of thought.

According to the elaboration likelihood model, the most persuasive strategy for people who have low motivation and/or ability to process the message (such as the uncommon behaviors groups in Study 2) is to use the peripheral route of processing. Therefore, a television commercial with an attractive celebrity using a catchy phrase to summarize the main hepatitis C risk factors would be the best way to structure a persuasive health message about hepatitis C to this group.

(Choices A and D) Detailed scientific facts and information presented by experts rely on the central route of processing, which is most effective for receivers who are highly motivated by the message. The results of Study 2 suggest that the uncommon behaviors groups are not highly concerned about contracting hepatitis C.

(Choice B) Needle sharing is an uncommon behavior; therefore, it does not appear to increase the concern for contracting hepatitis C as much as information regarding how

common behaviors can spread the disease.

Educational objective:

The elaboration likelihood model defines two routes of persuasion: The central route (focusing on the logical content of the message) is most effective when the audience is motivated by the message, whereas the peripheral route (focusing on superficial characteristics of the message) is more effective when people are not motivated by the message.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400503

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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	Likely/common	Unlikely/uncommon	Control
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	group	group	
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Table 2 Mean Concern of Contracting Hepatitis C Score, by Group and Condition

Number of behaviors	Common behaviors	Uncommon behaviors
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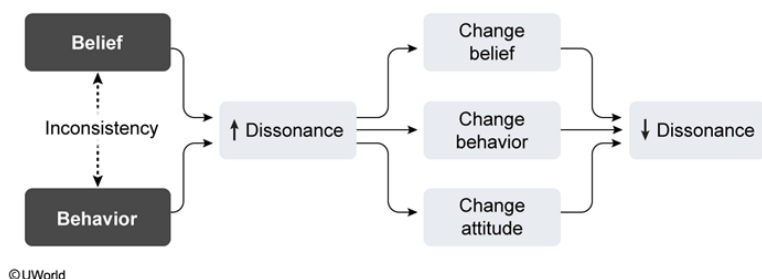
The results in Table 1 can also be explained by which of the following?

- ☐ A. Evolutionary game theory [11%]
- ✓ ☒ B. Cognitive dissonance theory [49%]
- ☐ C. Drive reduction theory [4%]
- ☐ D. Labeling theory [34%]

Correct

48% answered correctly

Explanation:



According to **cognitive dissonance theory**, cognitive dissonance (conflict) results from beliefs, attitudes, or behaviors that are dissonant, contradictory, or incompatible. For example, a person who runs and smokes (two contradictory behaviors) or a Republican (belief) who votes for a Democrat (contradictory behavior) should experience cognitive dissonance.

Cognitive dissonance causes a **state of discomfort** that results in motivation to reduce the conflict by **aligning thoughts** and/or **behaviors**. For example, the running smoker would be motivated to quit smoking and the Democrat-voting Republican would be motivated to change party affiliation.

Table 1 shows a higher estimated probability of "self" contracting meningitis (mean score = 35) for the likely/common group as compared to the other groups. These results, which support the hypothesis (the likely/common group will experience less self-positivity bias), can be explained by cognitive dissonance. Individuals initially believe they will never contract meningitis but then learn that it can be contracted through common behaviors, increasing cognitive dissonance. To reduce cognitive dissonance,

individuals are then more likely to change their attitude by acknowledging that they themselves could contract meningitis.

(Choice A) Evolutionary game theory (EGT) describes how complex social behaviors (eg, mating, aggression, altruism) persist in populations. By applying mathematical models, EGT predicts how organisms will interact and how their behaviors confer evolutionary advantage and are passed on to offspring. This study

does not assess social behaviors.

(Choice C) Drive reduction theory suggests that motivation results from the desire to maintain homeostasis. This study does not assess motivation, so this theory cannot explain the results.

(Choice D) Labeling theory suggests that when individuals are assigned a "deviant" label by others in society, they are more likely to behave in deviant ways, therefore justifying the label. This study does not assess social labels or deviance, so this theory cannot explain the results.

Educational objective:

According to cognitive dissonance theory, people are motivated to think and behave in ways that are cognitively consistent. Divergent thoughts and/or behaviors result in discomfort, motivating individuals to change their behaviors and/or attitudes so that they align.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

QID:400504

System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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Table 2 Mean Concern of Contracting Hepatitis C Score, by Group and Condition

Number of behaviors	Common behaviors	Uncommon behaviors
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Suppose the researchers in Study 2 conducted a follow-up experiment in which they asked all 120 participants to play the role of a health educator by presenting a 15-minute lecture on the risks of contracting hepatitis C to a group of high school students. This would most likely cause:

- ☐ A. a decrease in concern scores and preventive behaviors for all participants. [3%]
- ☒ B. an increase in concern scores and preventive behaviors for all participants. [84%]
- ☐ C. a decrease in concern scores for the common behaviors group only. [3%]
- ☐ D. an increase in concern scores for the uncommon behaviors group only. [8%]

Correct
85% answered correctly

Explanation:

Processes by which behavior influences attitude		
Foot-in-the-door phenomenon	Agreeing to a small request increases the chances of agreeing to a larger request.	eg, Lending a person \$5 increases the likelihood that an individual will lend that person \$100.
Cognitive dissonance	Conflicting thoughts/behaviors cause discomfort, which motivates alignment.	eg, Eating meat contradicts animal welfare beliefs, so a person becomes a vegetarian.

Role-playing effects	Behaving according to a role causes attitudes to align with behaviors.	eg, Defending an assigned debate topic stance causes a person to agree with it.
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A role refers to the specific behaviors that correspond to a particular position in society. Studies suggest that when individuals are asked to **play social roles**, the behaviors that align with those roles can **impact their attitudes**.

The **Stanford prison experiment** is the most famous study on role-playing and attitude. In this experiment, 24 male college students were randomly assigned the role of either prisoner or guard in a simulated prison. The researchers found that the behavior of the participants began to influence their attitudes to such an extent that the study was terminated prematurely out of concern for the participants' safety.

A person playing the role of health educator is expected to be knowledgeable about disease risks and to engage in preventive behaviors. Therefore, a follow-up experiment asking participants to play the role of a health educator would be most likely to cause changes in attitude (increase in concern for contracting hepatitis C) and changes in behavior (increase in preventive measures) for all participants.

(Choice A) Role-playing effects predict that attitudes and behaviors would align with the role of health educator, causing increases (not decreases) in concern and preventive behaviors.

(Choices C and D) Because all 120 participants are asked to play the role of health educator, all should demonstrate the changes in attitude and behavior that are predicted by role-playing effects.

Educational objective:

People tend to behave in ways that are consistent with the role they are playing. Role-playing effects, most famously demonstrated by the Stanford prison experiment, predict that when individuals are asked to behave in ways that align with an assigned role, they often demonstrate attitude changes.

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Behavioral Sciences

QID:400505
System:
Identity and Social Interaction

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Which of the following cognitive biases is most analogous to the self-positivity bias?

- ☐ A. Actor-observer bias [17%]
- ☐ B. Confirmation bias [8%]
- ☒ C. Optimism bias [48%]
- ☐ D. Overconfidence bias [25%]

Correct

49% answered correctly

Explanation:

Cognitive biases are irrational thought processes that commonly

occur and result in illogical conclusions. The self-positivity bias occurs when people believe that they are less vulnerable to negative outcomes than other people.

The **optimism bias** is very similar, and describes the tendency for people to **underestimate** the probability that **bad things** (eg, cancer, car accident) **will happen to them**. The two cognitive biases are most similar because each describes the human predilection for miscalculating the likelihood that adverse events will impact them.

(Choice A) The actor-observer bias occurs when individuals attribute other people's behavior to internal causes (eg, she yelled at her child because she's a terrible mother) while attributing their own behavior to external factors (eg, I yelled at my child because I had a bad day at work).

(Choice B) The confirmation bias is the tendency to look for information that supports the conclusion one has already reached, to ignore information undermining that conclusion, and to interpret ambiguous information as supporting the conclusion.

(Choice D) The overconfidence bias occurs when the degree to which people are sure of their belief is greater than the accuracy of that belief (ie, people overestimate their subjective knowledge compared to objective facts).

Educational objective:

Cognitive biases are irrational ways of thinking that impact thoughts and behavior. The optimism bias is a cognitive bias whereby people tend to underestimate the likelihood that bad things (eg, cancer) will happen to them.

Time spent:0 sec

Subject:

Behavioral Sciences

QID:400506

System:

Identity and Social Interaction

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